

What do you think about AI & its potential impact on our environment?

Posted by u/Staylowfm • 0 points • 38 comments

I've been doing research on AI and how it affects the environment. Data centers using too much water and electricity when training a new AI model. (Water used for cooling).

I'm looking for everyone else's opinions on this. & are people even going to step up and take action against this problem or no, do you think?

Comments

u/jacek2023 • 1 points • 2026-02-01 19:56 UTC

Do you think AI should eat meat?

u/optimisticalish • 1 points • 2026-02-01 18:16 UTC

We are in a very short transitional phase. In the slightly longer term (say, 10-15 years), AIs will lead to or outright invent *so many* new ways to conserve and restore nature that the positives will far outweigh the current drawbacks.

It will also invent ways to make itself far more efficient (and thus energy efficient), and indeed the field is already doing so on a daily basis. The old joke that 'this AI stuff will run on your toaster in a few years' is become less of a joke with every month that passes.

These processes will not stop, will likely accelerate, and will synergise with a thousand other developments in fields such as materials science, bio-tech, solar etc.

u/mystery_biscotti • 2 points • 2026-02-01 17:04 UTC

Okay, so... question, honest question: you're posting on Reddit, which lives in a data center, yes? Do you watch YouTube or TikTok content? Also data center. Have email? Data center.

****Data centers aren't just an AI thing.**** I think people have forgotten that.

AI companies aren't the only ones using data centers for their apps. You can absolutely run local models on a laptop you power with a solar charged battery too. I do that and run local on my desktop (which is only on an hour per day average).

My hope is development of powerful local models small enough to run on smaller devices becomes the norm. I appreciate that you're concerned about the environment. Me too, dude, me too. I recycle,

compost, buy most things second hand, monitor and improve on my food waste as much as I can, and have used my car last year less than ever before, and cut meat consumption.

u/Psionikus • 1 points • 2026-02-01 16:58 UTC

Our environmental impact is primarily the kind of problem that requires broad coordination, globally, and to yield benefits, must be enforced, globally. I don't like the fact that tuna contains high levels of methyl mercury. I want a solution, but approaching users downstream of industries one by one is basically all talk. If anything, companies that would feel annoyed by real action would do well to fund such "activism." Once the activists turn into unreasonable fanatics who ratchet up higher and higher volumes of hyperbole instead of going back to the drawing boards to think of better solutions, the political ire turns against that movement generally.

u/Apprehensive-End7926 • -1 points • 2026-02-01 16:58 UTC

So much of the criticism of AI energy use is based on misinformation. If you need to lie to make your point, how good can the point possibly be?

I do think data centre energy use is a significant issue, but AI only makes up about 20% of that and people aren't interested in talking about the other 80%.

u/Staylowfm • -1 points • 2026-02-01 19:28 UTC

AI still uses water though.

u/Apprehensive-End7926 • 1 points • 2026-02-01 19:30 UTC

Not any more than other data centre tasks. So why do you care so much about the 20% and not at all about the 80%? I don't think you care about the environment, what you really care about is moral posturing.

u/Staylowfm • 0 points • 2026-02-01 19:33 UTC

Okay!!

u/Low-Opening25 • 0 points • 2026-02-01 16:38 UTC

do they use water tho? it's not like cattle farming, datacenter don't burn or pollute water, it's either closed cycle or open cycle water circulation.

energy usage is just a question of source, if data center is 100% power by renewable energy then what's the problem?

u/TacticalSpoon69 • 4 points • 2026-02-01 16:35 UTC

Compute clusters barely use any water. Agriculture and thermoelectric power generation globally use about 90 trillion gallons of water per year. Total water used by US data centers in 2023 is around 17 billion gallons directly for cooling and around 211 billion gallons indirectly for electricity.

u/clayingmore • 6 points • 2026-02-01 16:32 UTC

With regards to water, I don't give it a second thought if I buy an extra bottle or run the tap for an extra 30s. Why would I be giving a second thought to my AI calls?

Lets shut down golf courses and almond farming rather than the AI that people are actually using.